Jobs, too, remain scarce in Bihar. Many Biharis, up to 10 per cent in some districts, still seek their fortunes in big cities. The migrants, conduits for remittances and modern ideas, help transform their families' fortunes back home. Outmigration isn't new in Bihar. In the late nineteenth century, exploitative agrarian policies of the British and the resulting famines pushed hundreds of thousands of Biharis to go as indentured labourers to British colonies overseas, such as the Caribbean, where they worked in sugar plantations (they replaced enslaved Africans, after slavery was abolished). In the late twentieth century, one such labourer's grandson and journalist, Shiva Naipaul, brother of V.S. Naipaul, would visit and accuse Bihar of being 'the Subcontinent's heart of darkness'.

Bihar's dismal present only makes it harder to imagine its illustrious past, when it was the beating heart of the subcontinent's high culture—imagined as Sita's home in the Ramayana; birthplace of the earliest republics;[2] land of the Buddha and Mahavira, Emperor Ashoka and the Mauryas; home to the cultural radiance of the Gupta Age, with its brilliant art, drama, literature and big advances in astronomy, mathematics, metallurgy, philosophy and other secular knowledge. Thousands of students—not only from India but also from China, Korea, Sumatra, Sri Lanka, Tibet, Japan and Central Asia—once flocked to Bihar for higher studies. Indeed, for nearly two millennia, Bihar was a creative, innovative and eventful place. Now it's a model backwater. What on earth happened to Bihar, I wonder, and to its great educational institutions like Nalanda?

The Rise of Nalanda

I'm rudely awakened the next morning by a rather unmelodic muezzin's call to prayer, and later again by an even louder tuneless man chanting Hanuman Chalisa into a loudspeaker right outside my hotel room's window. What are the odds of this double whammy? I think. Silently cursing them both, I get ready and leave for the ruins of Nalanda.

I hire an 'official guide', but I'm quickly disappointed. He gets too many details wrong, makes things up on the fly and whines about 'outsider guides' who accompany foreign tour groups and earn a lot more money than the local guides. I see only a few tourists; among them is a group of